Business

1. TSMC — the Taiwanese company that makes the chips inside your iPhone, your AI server, and basically everything else — just reported its latest quarterly results. What happened to its net profit?
   a. It fell slightly as customers delayed AI hardware orders
   b. It rose 68.7% to a record high
   c. It doubled, driven entirely by smartphone demand

2. The EU has just announced a new annual cap on Chinese hybrid electric vehicle imports. How many Chinese hybrid cars will EU countries be allowed to import each year under the new limit?
   a. 100,000
   b. 350,000
   c. 750,000

3. KFC has just announced a major switch for its US restaurants — ending a beverage partnership that has lasted roughly four decades. What is KFC changing, and who is the new partner?
   a. Switching from Coca-Cola to a private-label water brand to cut costs
   b. Switching from PepsiCo to Coca-Cola as its exclusive US drinks supplier
   c. Switching from PepsiCo to a rotating selection of craft soda brands

4. Elon Musk recently staged a flashy product demonstration that did not go down well with investors. Roughly how much wealth did he personally lose in a single day as a result?
   a. $3 billion, mostly in after-hours trading
   b. $20 billion, the largest single-day wealth drop globally
   c. $8 billion, spread across his Tesla and SpaceX stakes

Economics

5. The latest US inflation (Consumer Price Index — a measure of how fast prices are rising across a basket of everyday goods) came in at 3.7% in September. Which category was the biggest driver pushing it higher?
   a. Food prices, particularly eggs and fresh produce
   b. Energy prices, including petrol and airfares
   c. Housing costs, as rents hit a new peak

6. Germany's cabinet has just approved a new sugar tax on sweetened drinks, set to kick in from 1 July 2027. Which of these is NOT one of the stated reasons behind the policy?
   a. To help fund the statutory health insurance system
   b. To discourage excessive sugar consumption
   c. To raise revenue earmarked for school nutrition programmes

7. Vietnam and EFTA (the European Free Trade Association — a bloc including Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, and Liechtenstein) just signed a landmark free trade agreement in Hanoi. How long did negotiations take?
   a. 4 years
   b. 9 years
   c. 14 years

8. New EU data reveals just how many people cannot afford regular leisure activities — things like sport, cinema trips, or a meal out. What share of EU residents are in this position?
   a. Around 1 in 20 (roughly 23 million people)
   b. Around 1 in 8 (roughly 46 million people)
   c. Around 1 in 30 (roughly 15 million people)

General Knowledge

9. Which country is the world's largest producer of cobalt — a metal critical for electric vehicle batteries and rechargeable electronics?
   a. China
   b. Democratic Republic of Congo
   c. Australia

10. Which economist gave us the concept of 'invisible hand' — the idea that individuals pursuing their own self-interest can unintentionally benefit society as a whole?
   a. John Maynard Keynes
   b. David Ricardo
   c. Adam Smith

Business

1. TSMC — the Taiwanese company that makes the chips inside your iPhone, your AI server, and basically everything else — just reported its latest quarterly results. What happened to its net profit?

b. TSMC's net profit rose 68.7% to a record high in the third quarter. The surge was driven by insatiable global demand for AI hardware — the data centres and accelerator chips that power tools like ChatGPT. TSMC manufactures chips for Apple, Nvidia, and AMD, making it one of the most strategically important companies on the planet. No other foundry comes close to its advanced manufacturing capabilities.

2. The EU has just announced a new annual cap on Chinese hybrid electric vehicle imports. How many Chinese hybrid cars will EU countries be allowed to import each year under the new limit?

b. The European Commission set the cap at 350,000 hybrid vehicles per year. This follows earlier tariffs on Chinese battery electric vehicles and is part of a broader effort to protect European carmakers — particularly German and French brands — from lower-cost Chinese competition. Chinese EVs and hybrids can cost 20-30% less than equivalent European models, partly due to state subsidies.

3. KFC has just announced a major switch for its US restaurants — ending a beverage partnership that has lasted roughly four decades. What is KFC changing, and who is the new partner?

b. KFC is ditching PepsiCo and signing with Coca-Cola as its exclusive US beverage supplier, ending one of the longest-standing deals in fast food history. The partnership with Pepsi dated back around 40 years. This matters beyond the fizzy drinks aisle — exclusive pouring rights in major chains are fiercely contested because they lock in enormous volumes and shape brand exposure for millions of customers daily.

4. Elon Musk recently staged a flashy product demonstration that did not go down well with investors. Roughly how much wealth did he personally lose in a single day as a result?

b. Musk lost approximately $20 billion in a single day — the largest personal wealth wipe-out recorded globally that week. The trigger was Tesla's demonstration of a so-called 'flying car' Roadster that included a kickflip manoeuvre, which markets read as spectacle over substance. It is a reminder that for mega-billionaires whose wealth sits mostly in company stock, a bad product launch can cost more than most countries' annual budgets for entire departments.

Economics

5. The latest US inflation (Consumer Price Index — a measure of how fast prices are rising across a basket of everyday goods) came in at 3.7% in September. Which category was the biggest driver pushing it higher?

b. Energy prices — especially gasoline and airfares — were the primary driver of the September rise to 3.7%. This matters because energy costs ripple through the whole economy: higher fuel prices raise transport costs, which then push up the price of almost everything else. The Federal Reserve (the US central bank) watches these numbers closely when deciding whether to raise or cut interest rates.

6. Germany's cabinet has just approved a new sugar tax on sweetened drinks, set to kick in from 1 July 2027. Which of these is NOT one of the stated reasons behind the policy?

c. School nutrition programmes were not cited as a reason. The German government's stated goals are to ease pressure on the statutory health insurance system — avoiding the need to raise contributions — and to nudge people away from sugary drinks. Sugar taxes have been introduced in over 50 countries. The UK's version, introduced in 2018, led many manufacturers to quietly reformulate their drinks before the tax even took effect.

7. Vietnam and EFTA (the European Free Trade Association — a bloc including Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, and Liechtenstein) just signed a landmark free trade agreement in Hanoi. How long did negotiations take?

c. The Vietnam-EFTA Free Trade Agreement took 14 years to negotiate before being signed in October. Free trade agreements (deals that cut tariffs and other barriers to goods and services crossing borders) are notoriously slow to conclude because every sector — from agriculture to financial services — involves competing interests. Vietnam has been one of Asia's fastest-growing economies and has now signed trade deals with the EU, the UK, and multiple Asian blocs.

8. New EU data reveals just how many people cannot afford regular leisure activities — things like sport, cinema trips, or a meal out. What share of EU residents are in this position?

b. Approximately 1 in 8 EU residents — around 46 million people — cannot afford regular leisure activities. That figure is larger than the entire population of Poland. It is a striking reminder that aggregate economic statistics like GDP per capita (average output per person) can mask enormous inequality within wealthy blocs. The EU's average income looks comfortable; the distribution underneath it is far more uneven.

General Knowledge

9. Which country is the world's largest producer of cobalt — a metal critical for electric vehicle batteries and rechargeable electronics?

b. The Democratic Republic of Congo produces roughly 70% of the world's cobalt, making it the single most important supplier of a mineral that sits at the heart of the EV revolution. China dominates the refining and processing stage downstream. This geographic concentration is a major strategic concern for Western governments trying to secure supply chains for the clean energy transition.

10. Which economist gave us the concept of 'invisible hand' — the idea that individuals pursuing their own self-interest can unintentionally benefit society as a whole?

c. Adam Smith introduced the 'invisible hand' in his 1776 masterwork, The Wealth of Nations. His core insight was that competitive markets, without central direction, tend to allocate resources efficiently because sellers compete for buyers and prices adjust accordingly. Smith is often called the father of modern economics, though he also wrote extensively about the moral limits of self-interest — a nuance that tends to get lost in the retelling.